Chapter I

Free at Last

15-03-2030

It was Saturday. Jay had been up late the day before and almost slept through the whole day. He woke up around 6 p.m. and made his way into the living room of his apartment. He sat down on his couch, turned on the television and closed his eyes. Jay had gotten so used to living like this that he always knew what was coming at this hour so therefore for the first time in 6 months, he opened his eyes again. It wasn't playing the usual program. An emergency broadcast was playing. Jay sat up straight and paid close attention.

"DO NOT GO OUTSIDE. LOCK YOUR DOORS AND WINDOWS. A MIND ALTERING AND DEADLY VIRUS IS SPREADING WORLDWIDE. CURRENTLY IT IS SUSPECTED TO SPREAD THROUGH SALIVA. AVOID ANY TYPE OF PHYSICAL CONTACT WITH OTHER HUMANS AND ANIMALS. STAY INSIDE AND AWAIT FURTHER INSTRUCTIONS. CURRENTLY KNOWN SYMPTOMS ARE BURNING FEVER, COUGHING UP BLOOD, SUDDEN GRAY EYE COLOR AND SIGNIFICANT CHANGE IN BEHAVIOR."

Jay sat in disbelief. He looked over at his open window and quickly ran across the room and closed it shut. He grabbed the handle for the blinds but took a brief look outside before closing them. Rain was pouring down on the empty street outside. It was quiet. Almost peaceful. But that peacefulness turned to eeriness when Jay heard the warning repeat on the television. Suddenly the sound of sirens in the distance faded in as well. He closed the blinds and went back to his couch.

Jay kept his eyes glued to the screen like a newborn with an iPad. The same broadcast kept repeating. Suddenly a dreadful panic set in. A weird and horrible sense of existential dread followed by a huge amount of anxiety. But his racing and anxious mind was put to a halt by the broadcast suddenly shutting off. Now it was pure silence. The television became a black mirror wherein he sat. Seeing his reflection made him reflect on how mundane his life had become. How life had become so bleak. How lost he was. But his thoughts were once again cut off by something. The sound of someone running outside in the hallway of his apartment complex. Followed by loud banging on a door and a girl screaming. Then the banging turned to breaking and then the sound of a physical altercation. The girl's scream became louder and louder and louder - until it just stopped.

The panic stopped. But now fear set in. Jay was frozen. His heart beating fast and his breath irregular. He didn't move a muscle as he was listening out for any sounds. After a couple of minutes, he mustered the courage to stand up. His legs trembling like someone trying stilts for the first time, he made his way towards the front door. He looked out the peephole. The hallway

was empty. He backed away from the door and made his way into the kitchen. As he grabbed the handle to one of his drawers, he paused. He knew that opening the drawer would make a lot of noise as he hadn't installed them correctly into the cupboard. He tried to pull it open slowly and carefully but it was stuck. He had to pull it with force if he wanted it open.

Knock* *Knock* *Knock

Jay froze up once again. The knock was on his door this time.

Knock* *Knock* *Knock

His heart was beating even faster than before and he began to hyperventilate.

Knock* *Knock* *Knock

But then he noticed something.

Knock* *Knock* *Knock

The knocks came in intervals.

Knock* *Knock* *Knock

He counted.

Knock* *Knock* *Knock

One. Two. Three.

Knock* *Knock* *Knock

Three seconds between each knock.

Knock* *Knock* *Knock

He grabbed the drawer's handle tight and waited.

Knock* *Knock* *Knock

He flung open the drawer as the knocking happened and let go. It was silent. One. Two. Three. Four. Five. Six. The knocking had stopped. He carefully grabbed a knife from the drawer and tip-toed to the front door. He slowly moved his head towards the peephole.

Knock* *Knock* *Knock

"Fuck!", blurted out Jay. It was silent for a few seconds. Then.

Knock* *Knock* *Knock* *Knock* *Knock* *Knock* *Knock

The knocking became rapid and slowly turned from knocking to slamming. Then from slamming to kicking. Jay backed up quickly while pointing the knife to the door.

“What the fuck do you want!?”, yelled Jay with fear in his voice. There was no response. Just more aggressive kicking and slamming.

“I-I’ve got a fucking knife! I will use it, okay!? Leave me alone!”, said Jay with panic and desperation in his voice. But whatever was on the other side of the door didn’t stop.

Jay stood still. Looking at the door moving with each kick and punch. He knew it wasn’t long before either the door or the lock would give up. His eyes pointed down as his brain was working overtime. He closed them and kept thinking. He opened them again and noticed the shoe cupboard in the corner of his eye. His head darted towards the cupboard, as he ran over and moved it in front of the door. Followed by a stool. Another cupboard. Part of his couch and other furniture. He backed up from the furniture filled entrance hallway. Whatever was trying to make its way in wasn’t deterred by it though. The kicking and slamming continued. Each one more aggressive than the last. Suddenly, the sound of multiple footsteps could be heard outside of the door as well, followed up by the sound of people screaming. After a couple of minutes Jay realized that he had only bought himself time and the solution wasn’t blocking the door. He thought back to all of the apocalypse movies and TV shows which he grew up seeing. He had been infatuated with the subject since he was very young, so he had a slight idea of what to do. He knew he couldn’t rely on fictional movies but what he did know with full certainty was that he had to get out of his apartment. Quick. Luckily, he knew exactly how.

Equipped with a backpack filled with food, water, tools and a flashlight, Jay made his way down the fire escape which was luckily just outside of his apartment window. Jay had changed into cargo pants, a long-sleeved shirt and a bomber jacket. The knife was now in a holster on his hip. He walked out into the empty street, looking down both sides of the street. Both were equally empty. Still as eerie as before. After a bit of thinking, he looked up and saw a man looking down at him from one of the shut apartment windows. The man was staring at Jay with a worried look. Then Jay noticed another man staring at him from another window. Then another person. Then another. And another. Jay turned a full 360 degrees, seeing people stare at him from multiple windows. He then locked eyes with the first man again. Suddenly a rush of adrenaline pumped into Jay’s veins. Followed by excitement. Slowly turning his expressionless face into a genuinely happy and exuberant expression; his lips forming a huge smile. Noticing Jay’s change in expression, the man in the window went from worried to confused. After staring back at the man with a deranged smile for a couple of seconds, Jay lifted his hand up to his forehead and saluted the man. The man now realized that Jay wasn’t someone going back into their apartment but instead someone leaving their apartment. He started waving his hands and shaking his head but Jay’s mind was set. He wasn’t going back. The chains were finally off. Life was what he wanted it to be. Free.

Chapter II

A Whole New World

18-03-2030

It had been three days since Jay left his apartment. He did nothing but walk and sightsee for those three days. Sleeping on benches for only a couple of hours before being awakened by different creepy and mysterious sounds. The weather was cloudy and it would occasionally rain. He had made it out of the city and was now walking down a road surrounded by forests on both sides. It was empty. Not a single car had passed him by and he had seen no signs of animals nor humans. It was like the whole world had gone into a coma besides him. After having walked down the road for a while, he noticed a gas station in the distance.

The building had a couple of windows so Jay could look through. He went up to one of them and peered through the glass. The lights were turned off and there were no signs of activity. Shelves were stocked and every item inside looked untouched. Bells attached to the door rang as Jay made his way inside. He looked around the store. He was hesitant to call out for anybody as the last interaction he had with somebody wasn't exactly a pleasant experience. After walking around a bit, he found a light switch. Nothing happened as he flipped it. He wondered why the power wouldn't work as it had only been a couple of days since the pandemic started. It usually takes a couple of weeks before that happens in the zombie apocalypse movies.

After stocking up on food and water, Jay went into the back of the store. He had never worked at a gas station before so he was curious as to how it looked in the backroom. On his way into the back, he felt his foot pull on something. Just as he was about to look down and see what it was, a can fell onto the ground and made a huge thwump.

"Jesus!", yelled Jay in fear. The can slowly rolled towards him. His eyes followed it as it came towards him and then he noticed. The can had a rope attached to it. Jay had triggered a homemade alarm trap. Before Jay could react to his realization, he heard someone walking behind him.

"Don't move.", said a manly voice behind Jay. Jay froze up and felt a cold sensation move through his entire body. He was terrified.

"Okay.", responded Jay.

"Oh, thank God.", said the unknown man and let out a sigh of relief. The terror turned to confusion but Jay still didn't dare move.

"Dude, I thought you were one of them.", said the man, followed by silence from both Jay and him. The man looked at Jay with confusion. "You can move, dude."

"Oh okay, sorry, I-", said Jay while turning around, "Man.", Jay felt a weird kind of relief, "It's good to see another person."

"Likewise, dude.", said the man. He had a semi-buff build, was wearing a Circle-K uniform and had a necklace of a cross around his neck. His expression was gleeful and innocent and Jay felt at ease seeing his relaxed demeanor. But then he noticed something.

“I was starting to worry, you know?”, said the man. His smile slowly disappeared and was replaced by a frown. Jay looked at him with confusion while slowly reaching for his knife.

“Worry about what?”

“Whether I was the only uninfected person left out here. I don’t know how much longer I would have been able to last on my own.”

“What do you mean? Why not?”

The man let out a slight chuckle while Jay looked at him with a serious stern look making him realize that Jay wasn’t fully aware of what was going on. At the same time, Jay firmly grabbed his knife.

“Dude, are you serious? *Why not*? Because there are dozens of mindless psychopathic killers roaming outside, my guy.”

Jay let go of the knife. He had noticed blood on the man’s face but as he finished the sentence, Jay saw it differently.

“Mind altering and deadly…”, Jay paused while picturing the emergency broadcast in his head, “I see.”

“Dude, are you telling me you didn’t know?”, said the man with a flabbergasted look on his face. “How can you not know? It was literally broadcasted and posted everywhere before everything went down.”

“Well yeah, I saw the broadcast on my TV but I lost my phone the day it started. They didn’t say anything about mindless killers though.”

“Yeah, they did, dude. Around midnight, they changed the message to something along the lines of: ‘people infected by the virus turn into killers devoid of any humanity.’ I literally saw it on that TV up there.”, said the man and pointed to a small TV hanging in the corner of the gas station.

“Jesus.”, Jay realized how lucky he had been not to stumble into anyone infected, “I had to leave my apartment before midnight. There was some psycho- well, I guess an infected person trying to get into my place.”, Jay paused briefly while rethinking his actions, “I guess I made the right choice.”

“Damn. You’re one lucky son of a bitch, dude.”, said the man with a chuckle. “I’m Chris by the way”, said Chris as he reached his hand out while smiling.

“Jay.”, said Jay while shaking Chris’ hand, “I’m glad you’re the first person I stumbled into.”

“Likewise, brother.”

Chapter III

An Empty Shell

18-03-2030

"So we're fucked.", said Jay and downed a bottle of water. It had been a couple of hours since he met Chris. Chris had a camp set up on the roof of the gas station with three medium sized tents and a Trangia kitchen in the middle of them. One tent had a mattress inside with three sleeping bags on it. Another had tons of bottled water and canned food and the third was full of random miscellaneous items. Jay and Chris were sitting in two folding festival chairs.

"Basically, yeah dude.", said Chris while eating from a can of soup.

"They really just said it was too late and that was it?"

"Yeah man. The broadcast said like: 'It's too late to stop. If they can't speak, kill them.' and then shortly after everything went dark."

"Fucking hell. So this is life now, huh?", said Jay, affirmed by a nod from Chris, "This is fucking insane. Like you've seen the zombie apocalypse movies but it was always just fiction. Now it's reality."

"Yeah, dude, I know. It's hard to fathom. Like, now those movies are in the same category as Bear Grylls' Survival School.", joked Chris, making them both laugh slightly. They both didn't say anything for a while.

"How do we know that we're not infected as well?", asked Jay while turning to Chris with a worried expression.

"Well, last time I checked we weren't mindless psychopaths trying to kill each other."

"Yeah, I guess you've got a point.", they smiled at each other, "But maybe it just takes a while before it fully spreads."

"Maybe.", Chris threw the can of soup off the roof, "Maybe not. It doesn't matter right now, dude. All we can do is take things as they come, you know."

"Yeah, you're right.", said Jay while nodding in agreement.

"What *does* matter though, dude, is that you learn how to fight them.", Chris gave Jay a stern look, "Like I said, the most important thing - they are not human anymore, okay?"

"Yeah-yeah, I know. I get it. And they move very erratically and they can't speak, right?"

"Right on, dude."

"It's just-", Jay paused to let out a sigh, "To kill another person, like, I'm not sure-", Chris abruptly interrupted Jay.

"What did I *just* say, dude? They're not people. Once they're infected, there is no person inside of that body anymore. It's just-", Chris turned his head down while fidgeting with his hands, "Just an empty shell once occupied by a soul."

Jay turned his eyes to Chris' hands, reflecting on whether or not it would be a good idea to dig deeper into the subject.

"It was someone close, wasn't it?", asked Jay. Chris kept the same position. Head still pointing towards the ground.

“It was my sister. She-”, Jay noticed a tear hit the ground from underneath Chris’ ducked head, “She works-- worked. She worked here as well. It was the day after the broadcast. Suddenly she lunged at me out of nowhere. Clawed for my face. I kept yelling at her, asking what she was doing. But she didn’t respond. She just growled at me. And so after wrestling for a bit, I got on top of her. Held her down. And then I looked straight into her eyes.”, Chris held a long pause, “She wasn’t there anymore. My sister was gone, dude.”

Jay and Chris sat in silence for a while. Chris was fidgeting with his hands even more than before. Still staring down at the ground. Jay looked at Chris with grief and sorrow.

“I’m so sorry, Chris. That’s-that’s fucking terrible, man. No one should go through that.”, Chris didn’t respond, “What was her name?”

Chris pulled his sleeve over his hand and wiped his eyes with it. He then looked up at Jay with a sorrowful smile.

“Cassandra. The best fucking sister I could have ever wished for, man.”

Jay smiled back at Chris and put his hand on his shoulder to comfort him.

“I believe that. And I’m sure God is taking good care of her.”

“He fucking better.”, chuckled Chris with a pain in his voice while tightly gripping the cross on his necklace.

Chapter IV

Not. Human

19-03-2030

"Wakey, wakey, dude.", said Chris while lifting the fabric in front of the entrance to the tent. Jay slowly opened his eyes and let out a yawn as he stretched.

"What time is it?"

"I don't fucking know, dude. How would I know that?"

"Oh yeah, sorry, shit. I'm still getting used to the new li-"

Jay was interrupted by the sound of the doorbells ringing followed up by a loud bang from underneath them inside of the gas station. Jay's eyes quickly darted and locked with Chris'. Both with an equally terrified look. Chris let go of the fabric and made his way towards the miscellaneous tent. Jay slowly followed behind and tiptoed his way out of the tent and to Chris.

"Here.", whispered Chris and handed Jay a machete while he held one himself. Jay studied the machete for a brief moment before he was interrupted by Chris grabbing his right arm with a firm grip.

"Not. Human.", whispered Chris and gave Jay a stern look. Jay nodded and they made their way towards the ladder going down from the roof.

Chris slowly made his way down the ladder first. At the bottom, he signaled Jay to crawl down as he looked around the forest surrounding the gas station. Jay slowly made his way down as well. Each step more careful than the next. Another loud bang came from inside the gas station, almost making Jay slip on one of the steps of the ladder. The banging then turned into the sound of rapid steps. Someone was running around inside of the store, knocking things down. "Dude, hurry up.", whispered Chris and shook his head to the side. Jay began to go down the steps faster. He was starting to get nervous. His palms and forehead got sweaty and his motor skills began to fail him. Chris got impatient and silently made his way towards the backroom door, carefully pulling the handle and opening the door. Just as he was about to peek inside, one of the steps of the ladder broke and Jay crashed down onto the ground, the machete falling out of his hand. Chris quickly turned his head towards Jay. Everything went silent. After trying to feel if he broke anything, Jay came to again and looked over at Chris. Chris was staring back at Jay without moving a single muscle so Jay stopped moving as well. The sounds from inside the gas station had stopped. It was pure silence.

Suddenly the sound of footsteps in quick succession could be heard from inside the backroom but before any of them could react, a man hurled into Chris, knocking him to the ground. The machete he held flew out of his hands and the man sat on top of Chris, clawing for his face. Jay froze. A flashback of when he froze in the apartment popped into his head. Chris yelled out for Jay but he was frozen stiff. Chris was fighting for his life, holding both of the man's arms, trying his best to hold him back. Jay looked in terror as the man grabbed a piece of a broken flask from the ground and stabbed it into Chris' shoulder. Chris let go of one of the arms as the blood poured out. The man then grabbed the arm he let go with and bit straight into it.

Jay's eyes filled with horror and opened wide as he saw the blood seeping out from the bite wound as well.

"Not. Human."

Jay unfroze and quickly stood up, grabbing the machete from the ground as he rushed towards the man. The man was about to stab Chris a second time but was interrupted by Jay slashing the machete into the man's arm. He cut half into it and then followed it up by pulling it out and sending the tip of it straight into the man's head. His body fell off of Chris and Jay quickly took off his bomber jacket and placed it on top of the stab wound in Chris' shoulder. As he tended to the bite wound, he looked into Chris' eyes. There was a gray spot in the middle of both of his pupils. It slowly started growing, covering the brown color in Chris' eyes.

"Shit, no, Chris, you're gonna be okay, alright? I-I'll get the first aid from the-from the tent, okay? Ju-just hold on.", said Jay and stood up to sprint towards the ladder but was then interrupted by Chris grabbing his leg.

"You remember I said we would take things as they come. Well, one of those things has come, Jay."

"Chris, no-no-no, I'll get the first aid kit and-", Chris tightened his grip and looked into Jay's eyes, his pupils having been almost entirely covered by the gray.

"I'm so fucking sorry, Chris.", Jay looked with sorrow at Chris, "It's my fucking fault, man. I froze. I fucking froze, I'm so sorry."

"Brother.", said Chris while trying to smile, "It's okay. I'll go visit my sister now."

Chris let go and grabbed his necklace, pulling it off of his neck with the last amount of strength he had left, handing it to Jay.

"Survive for me, man.", said Chris softly as Jay saw his soul leave his body, the eyes now being entirely covered by the gray. As his consciousness faded, he muttered his last words, "Don't fuck it up…"

Jay stared at Chris' lifeless body. After only a meer ten seconds, Chris' body began to shake and foam slowly seeped out of his mouth. Jay was all too familiar with the sight. Jay kept staring at Chris' body, contemplating whether or not he could do what he knew he had to do. A tear left his eye, he wiped it away and picked up Chris' machete from the ground. Raising it up high above Chris' head, he only had one thought pass through his mind.

"Not. Human."

Chapter V

Adapting To The Lifestyle

07-04-2030

The first emergency broadcast was on the 15th of March. It was now the 7th of April. Jay was sitting on top of the gas station, looking out into the dark moving forest. The trees were swaying from side to side as wind breezed through the leaves and branches. Jay had grown a stubble and was now wearing a wind jacket instead of the bomber jacket. He left it with Chris' body in a grave he dug for him shortly after the incident.

He picked up a knife sharpener and thoroughly sharpened the knife he held. It was the knife he brought with him when he left the apartment at the beginning of the pandemic. It was no longer in the same pristine condition as before, instead it was dull and covered in blood. Suddenly a woman came running out from the forest and stood in front of the gas station. Jay stopped sharpening and looked at her. Her head was moving erratically from side to side like she was searching for prey. After studying her movement for a moment, Jay went back to sharpening his knife. Shortly thereafter, the woman ran off into the forest again.

At this point, Jay was used to the new life. He had killed four more infected people since Chris' death and counted each one. In one of the tents which Chris had set up on the roof, Jay found a small notebook calendar in which he marked an X for each infected he had killed on the dates on which he killed them. He still wasn't used to killing infected people, so therefore he did it as a way to keep himself human. To stay grounded in the old ways of life and not make it a normal everyday thing. A day where he didn't mark an X in the calendar was a successful day.

After Jay finished sharpening the knife, he made his way down the roof. Jay had been living solely on water for 24 hours and had prepared to go out and look for food. He was equipped with a backpack filled with two bottles of water and different tools. A wirecutter, crowbar, hammer, flashlight and a screwdriver. Around his waist was a hatchet on his right and the newly sharpened knife on his left. Jay was well-aware of the fact that he might not be able to find his way back, so he had packed for a long journey. He had no phone, no map, no radio, no GPS - nothing to help him find his way back. As he made his way out in front of the gas station, he looked across the road into the forest. It was where Jay had made Chris' grave. It was marked by a crooked wooden cross with 'Chris' written on it with chalk. Jay kept his eyes glued to it, grabbing the cross pendant necklace Chris gave him, before making his way down the road into the unknown.

It was nighttime. Jay was still walking down the road but the forest had ended and he was instead surrounded by huge fields with farmhouses visible far out in the distance. He had thought about making his way out to one but he was worried that they would have already been scavenged or be filled with infected. He was betting on another gas station along the road but after hours of traveling, he was starting to give up hope. Suddenly, he could see lights far out in the distance. Slowly the lights got closer and grew brighter. It was a car.

“Hey!”, yelled Jay as the car got closer. He pulled out the flashlight from his backpack, turned it on and started swinging it from side to side to get the driver’s attention. He was overjoyed. He had passed by cars on the way but they either had an empty tank or didn’t have a key. Traveling in a car would be a huge help.

“Hey, slow down!”, yelled out Jay as he noticed that the car was speeding up. He could hear the revving of the engine getting louder and louder. Suddenly the car turned on its high beams and blinded Jay. He covered his eyes with his hand and peeked out from between his fingers. He could barely see anything but the lights. He began to panic. He could feel his body starting to freeze up but he quickly snapped out of it and looked from side to side. On the side of the road was a speed limit sign. As time was just about to run out, Jay turned off his flashlight, ran towards the sign and jumped behind it. The car flew by. Jay’s heart was racing. He quickly made his way around the sign so he stood on the opposite side. Luckily, the car continued to drive and Jay calmed down again.

“What the fuck?”, thought Jay to himself as he looked at the car drive away but before he could collect his thoughts, he heard the sound of a dozen footsteps and tons of growling behind him. He turned around and saw a bunch of infected people running straight his way in the distance.

“Fuck”, muttered Jay as he began to sprint towards one of the farmhouses he had seen far out in the field. The field was muddy and uneven so Jay would occasionally trip on his way. He was wearing sneakers which weren't ideal for the type of terrain he was running in. While sprinting with all of his might, he kept looking behind him to see if any of the infected were following him. The darkness made it hard for him to see clearly and the sound of his heart beating and feet trekking through the mud made it so he couldn’t hear if he was being followed either. After ten minutes of running on an adrenaline filled body, he fell to the ground out of exhaustion. He peered into the darkness and listened out for any footsteps or growling. Besides the sound of his heavy breathing and rapidly beating heart, it was quiet. After catching his breath again, he stood up, turned around and slowly made his way towards the farmhouse. It was only a couple of kilometers away from him now.

Jay stood in front of the two story farmhouse. Through the windows was pure darkness. There wasn't a single sign of life in the vicinity. But still, Jay snuck his way around the house to the front door, looking around as he snuck. On the way, he noticed two cars in front of the house. He walked up two steps onto the porch where the front door was. Before trying the door, he peeked through a window on the side of the door. He had a better view of the inside but still saw no sign of life. Though seeing as there were two cars in the driveway he didn’t rule out somebody being home regardless. He pulled out the hatchet from his belt and grabbed the doorknob. Locked. A familiar coldness went through Jay’s entire body. There were cars. The door was locked. He wasn’t alone.

As the realization set in, a creak came from inside the house. Jay readied his hatchet, prepared to swing it. Another creak. And another. Jay slowly tiptoed to the window again to peek

inside. Just as he turned his head to look through, he saw a middle-aged man's face looking straight into his eyes from inside the house.

"Fucking hell!", let out Jay in shock as he stepped back from the window alongside the person inside. Before Jay could react further, the sound of a shotgun cock came from inside the house. Jay's eyes widened and he instantly jumped to the floor as the shotgun blasted through the window. The glass shattered and the pieces fell on top of Jay and onto the wooden porch. Jay crawled away as fast as he could, slicing his hands on the glass shards, meanwhile the man inside cocked the shotgun again.

"Hey-hey, I'm not one of them!", yelled Jay to the man, hoping to calm the man down.

"Sure, you're not.", responded the man and blasted through the front door, almost hitting Jay who was sitting right beside it.

"Are you fucking insane!? Listen, I can talk, you idiot! The infected can't talk!", said Jay in a panicked voice as he swiftly crawled off the porch and around the corner of the house.

"That's exactly what one of them would say.", said the man as he cocked the shotgun again and made his way out the front door.

Jay peeked from behind the corner and saw the big man standing on the porch with the shotgun in hand. Attached was a flashlight which he pointed around to look for Jay.

"I saw the broadcast, you bastard. Heh, you can't trick me. No-no. I know exactly what you are. I know that you act and talk like a human but you are far from one.", said the man as he shone his light into the darkness. Jay wanted to respond, but he knew that would give away his position. He put the hatchet back in his belt and pulled out his knife. While he tried to think of what to do, the man noticed a blood trail which Jay had left when he slit his hands open on the glass. The man slowly made his way down the porch and towards the corner where Jay stood.

"Die, you parasite.", said the man as he blasted through the wooden wall corner, followed by a quick shotgun cock, blast and another shotgun cock.

It went quiet. The man slowly made his way around the corner while pointing the shotgun. He turned the corner but it was empty.

"I'm so sorry.", whispered Jay behind the man as he thrusted the knife into the side of the man's head in the process making him shoot off the shotgun post-mortem. The blast knocked Jay and the man to the ground, his body laying on top of Jay. The loud blast made his ears ring as he laid on the ground covered in the man's blood. Jay had closed his eyes when he fell and when he opened them, he was looking straight into the sky. Suddenly a shooting star flew by. His eyes began to water, the tears pulling the blood down his face, and his expression turned apologetic.

"I tried…", whispered Jay with sorrow in his voice as he grabbed onto the cross pendant necklace tightly.

"Please forgive me."

Jay sat on the porch of the farmhouse and marked an X on the 7th. He looked up from the calendar. In front of him was a crooked wooden cross with the name 'Billy' written on it with

chalk. Jay had spent the morning searching through the house and had found a picture frame with a picture of the man, two kids and a woman on it. He had pulled out the picture and on the back of it stood the names of all of them. He had no idea where the kids and woman were.

The farmhouse had a couple of snacks and canned food which Jay sat and ate some of. After finishing, he made his way to the two cars. He pulled out a key from his pocket and tried the door on one of them. It fit. He put the key in the ignition and turned the key. The engine started revving. Jay looked at the dashboard as the tank meter arrow slowly made its way to 'F'. He loaded the backseat up with his backpack, an extra tire, a gas can and other miscellaneous things he had found on the property. The engine revved once again and as he was about to pull out of the driveway, he noticed the wooden cross in the side mirror. He paused as he thought about what he had done to sit behind the wheel of the car. The remorse and sorrow he felt when he laid on the ground, covered in blood with Billy's body on top of him, was still there. Deep inside of him. But he knew he had to let it go. There was no room for that anymore. Not in this world. It was kill or be killed. He looked away and put the car in drive, going off into the unknown once more.

Chapter VI

Bo's Banging Bar

12-04-2030

The engine loudly spurted as Jay carefully pulled onto the sidewalk and shut the engine off. The tank was almost empty. The door to the backseat creaked as Jay pulled it open and took out the gas can. 'Copenville' was written on a sign in the suburban neighborhood where Jay had ended up. He scanned his surroundings, trying to create a mental picture of the place, so he could find his way back. Luckily there was a tall flagpole close to where he stood. The flag sitting on top of the pole had half of it burned. After putting on his backpack, he made his way towards the center of the town. As he walked, he examined the houses passing him by. All the houses in the area were empty and the neighborhood was quiet. Only the sound of wind and tree branches rattling could be heard. Some houses looked untouched with cars still sitting in the driveways. Others looked like they had been completely ransacked. Doors were either hanging off of the hinges or were shut and had nails poking out. Windows were either smashed or entirely covered by something, creating a bleak darkness inside of the window frames. So much had changed in just four weeks and then it occurred to Jay. It was truly the apocalypse.

Jay was walking down the street in the center of the town. The town looked worse than the residential properties. The street, sidewalks, stores, buildings - it looked like the aftermath of a massive riot. Trash littering everywhere, windows and doors broken and worst of all - bloody streets. There were not many but tragically still corpses lying around the streets. Jay walked up to one, examining the ground around it. Bullet casing surrounded the body and the gender was unidentifiable. It was the scene of a gory horror movie. Sadly, it caused no amount of disgust or emotion in Jay. He was tragically used to the new way of life. There was no point in mourning the dead as that would have him mourning everyday. He felt wrong not having any reaction to the horrifying scene but it was like having to sleep somewhere new everyday. You get used to it.

As he stood above the corpse, he was suddenly alerted by the sound of something falling over. He turned around immediately and saw an infected teenage girl crawling out from one of the stores, trying its best to move towards him. For some reason, the legs of the infected were limb so it could only crawl. It growled and looked at Jay with empty eyes. He put down the gas can and pulled out the shotgun which he had on a strap around his torso. He walked up to the slow crawling infected, aimed the shotgun at it and gave it a pitiful look. Before he shot, a quick glimpse of Chris' eyes being covered by the gray flashed into his head. The shotgun blast was loud, resulting in the birds in the surrounding area flying away while croaking loudly. He was down to six slugs now. Just as he was about to move on and scavenge the stores, multiple footsteps could be heard in the distance. Jay looked down the street and saw infected people coming out from everywhere. His eyes widened and his heart started racing. He turned around but down the other side of the street came infected people running as well. They were still a good distance away but it wasn't long before they would be at his location. Jay's eyes darted around, scanning the surrounding buildings. He then noticed a building with a sign hanging above it

saying: ‘Bo’s Banging Bar’. The building didn’t have any windows on the outside and the door was open. He left the gas can behind and with all the haste possible, Jay ran inside of the building and smacked the door shut. There was no lock. He turned around and looked for something to block the door with. Luckily for Jay, he had made his way into a bar. In the middle of the room stood two pool tables surrounded by tables, chairs and a bar countertop. The first thing he tried was pushing the pool table towards the door but it was too heavy. Second thing was lifting all the chairs in the way of the door but as the infected made their way to the door and started kicking and pushing, he noticed it wouldn’t hold. Third thing was pushing all the tables in front but as he was about to push the last one in the way, he heard a door from behind the bar fling open. Before he could react, two infected came running out from the room behind the bar. Jay pulled out the shotgun again and shot the first one in the stomach, knocking it to the ground. The second one jumped over the counter and ran towards Jay with a knife in hand. He quickly cocked the shotgun and was about to fire another shot but was interrupted by the infected lifting the knife up high and thrusting it towards his face. With two swift motions, Jay blocked the attack with the shotgun and hit it in the side of the head with the butt of the shotgun, knocking it unconscious. Meanwhile, another infected had made its way in through the backroom. Jay was starting to become overwhelmed as the sound of the infected banging on the front door behind him was getting louder and more erratic. Suddenly the sound of gunshots outside could be heard but he didn’t have time to think about that as he knew that he didn’t have much time left before the infected would get in, so he hastily ran towards the room behind the bar, shooting the infected on the way with ease. He cocked and threw the shotgun over his shoulder, making it sit on his back from the strap around his body. He jumped over the counter and made his way into the backroom. It was a kitchen. His eyes searched for the entry point as he breathed heavily. Then he noticed the door which they had made their way in from. As he ran towards it, it flung open. In quick succession, Jay grabbed the shotgun from his back and aimed.

“Don’t shoot!”, said the man Jay was pointing his shotgun at. The man looked like he had just come home from vacation, wearing a Hawaiin shirt and blue shorts. Both didn’t fit him. Jay stood frozen, staring at the man while trying to collect his thoughts. Jay quickly snapped out of it and waved his hand in a gesture signaling that the man had to move. The man moved away as Jay slammed the door shut and stood with his back up against it. He could feel as the infected began pushing against the door, trying to make their way in. Meanwhile Jay used all the strength he had left to keep the door shut, the man stood still and looked at Jay with a fearful expression.

“Go find something!”, yelled Jay at the man with anger in his voice.

“Sor-sorry, sorry!”, said the man fearfully and began to look around the kitchen for something to block the door with. Jay was trying his best to hold them back but he could feel more and more force against his back as seconds went by.

“Hurry!”, yelled Jay out of desperation. The man was still looking around the kitchen.

“I’m trying! I-I-I’m-I’m looking!”, said the man as he darted around the room. Jay wasn’t able to hold it any longer but as one last-ditch effort, Jay stretched his hands out and grabbed onto a dishwasher which sat up against the wall next to him, and pulled it with all of his might.

As he slowly pulled the dishwasher away from the wall and towards him the floor creaked, sounding like nails going down a chalkboard. He moved away as he pushed the dishwasher in front of the door and thereafter leaned up against it to catch his breath. The infected were still pushing against the door but the dishwasher was luckily holding them back. When he caught his breath, Jay turned around and looked at the man who stood frozen in front of him - staring at him with a horrified expression. Jay was furious and looked at him with visible anger.

"What… the *fuck* was that!? What were you doing? Huh? You almost got us fucking killed, you idiot! All you had to do was find something to block the door with instead the guy holding the fucking door had to do it. What the fuck is wrong with you!?", said Jay in an enraged state. The man was silent for a brief moment as Jay looked at him with tremendous anger.

"I don't know… I'm-I'm sorry, I-I just… I can't think straight." said the man while sounding like he was about to cry. Jay was about to yell at him again before the sounds of the infected trying to break in reminded him of the situation they were in.

"Whatever. We gotta get out of here. Fast.", said Jay and walked back into the bar room. The chairs and tables blocking the front door had moved back a significant amount so he quickly ran behind one of the pool tables.

"Make up for that shit.", Jay moved his head toward the kitchen, "And help move this.", said Jay and began to push the pool table. The man quickly ran to Jay and helped him push it. They slowly pushed the pool table towards the door and blocked it. Jay backed up from it to see how well it would hold. It barely moved as the infected pushed against the door. Jay calmed down a bit and started thinking of a plan. He knew that they would eventually break through one of the doors, so he had only bought them time.

"What now? We stay put?", asked the man.

"No, we can't do that. We need to get out of here somehow.", responded Jay while moving his hair back with his hands.

"I have no idea how though.", continued Jay as he began to look around the bar. The man stood still, his eyes moving around as if he was thinking about something.

"I uhh- I might.", said the man and looked at Jay. Jay quickly turned his head towards him.

"I once worked in- uhh, the-the store next to this building and if I'm not mistaken-", the man walked into the kitchen while Jay followed behind, "The buildings are identical.", said the man and looked up at a trapdoor in the ceiling. Jay looked impressed.

"Good thinking. How do we get it open?", said Jay while examining the trapdoor.

"Well, that's the problem. We need this, like, long metal pole thing to unlock it. You put it in the hole and then twist it so-", before the man could finish his sentence, Jay shot through the trapdoor with his shotgun making the man cover his ears in shock. The trapdoor flew open and out fell a folding wooden ladder, luckily still intact.

"Alright, let's go.", said Jay as he folded the wooden ladder out. The man was still covering his ears but stopped when Jay gestured for him to go up the ladder.

The ladder led up to the roof where Jay and the man were now standing. The infected's banging and growling could be heard around them while they carefully tiptoed to the edge of the roof, peeking over the railing surrounding the rooftop. The front door had at least twenty infected trying to make their way into the bar. The backdoor had an equal amount. Jay carefully walked to the trapdoor and tried to close it again but the lock keeping it shut was broken from the shotgun blast. Jay muttered curse words at himself because of his reckless behavior.

"What do we do now?", whispered the man and looked at Jay with worry. Jay grabbed his forehead and closed his eyes. He had no idea. It wouldn't be too long before the infected would make it through one of the blocked doors and they couldn't hide on the roof because Jay had shot off the lock, rendering the trapdoor permanently open. They could sit and hold it closed but it could be hours before the infected would leave. Maybe days. The man realized that Jay had no clue.

"Oh God… I-I can't… I'm sorry.", tears ran down the man's face, "Matthias… I tried… I just- I can't… I can't take anymore…", said the man with a sobbing speech. Jay looked at the man with pity. He was reminded of how he felt when he was first introduced to the reality of the pandemic. How hard it was to fathom that a virus was turning people into raving lunatics stripped of all humanity. That killing people was now an everyday occurence and part of survival. That what life used to be was over and it was the start of a new age. There was no longer any worry about looks, age, smell, identity, career, gender, size, height - all of that was meaningless now. No more hanging out with friends, going to work, watching TV shows, partying, relaxing - that was all gone. Society had crumbled in four weeks and all that was left was survival. Just four weeks for everything built over 2030 years to be gone. Four weeks.

"What's your name?", asked Jay in a quiet voice. The man looked at Jay with teary eyes.

"I-It's uh- it's Woodland. But I go by Woods.", said Woods with a choked speech. He wiped away the tears from his face and tried to stop his crying.

"Okay, listen Woods, I'm Jay. And I haven't made it all the way here just to die on this roof, okay? So just give me a second to think.", said Jay to calm Woods. Woods was still distressed but he took a deep breath and nodded.

"Okay.", said Woods in a quiet voice. Jay scanned the rooftop as well as the street and buildings around them. There were buildings on both sides of the bar but the distance was too far to jump. On the other side of the street was a supermarket but the windows were broken so they wouldn't be able to run to it and hide. Making their way down from the roof wasn't an option either as the infected were surrounding the building. They could try to outrun them but it was too dangerous considering the huge amount of infected. Jay was starting to panic on the inside as he couldn't think of anything to get them to safety but he didn't show it on the outside to keep Woods calm. He wondered how Woods had survived until now considering his obvious lack of survival skills. First the freezing and now the sobbing and hopelessness. How could he have survived four weeks in this chaotic and deadly landscape?

Chapter VII

The Nash Family

17-03-2030

The emergency broadcast was blaring out of the speakers connected to Woods' PC while he was surfing through the web. He had pages open for every social media. Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, Reddit, TikTok, etc. Behind him stood his mom, Jeniffer, and brother, Matthias, with eyes glued to the computer screen. They all wore face masks. The sound of sirens and cars driving past at full speed could be heard outside of their house.

"Look, see this video!", said Woods and played a video on the TikTok webpage. It was a handheld phone recording from an apartment window of police with riot shields and guns, shooting at multiple people running at them. The caption said: 'People are going crazy outside. Do what the broadcast says, it is NOT fake.' The video cut off just before the horde of people overwhelmed the police. Jennifer gasped.

"Oh my God.", Jennifer looked at the screen horrified, "So the virus makes you go crazy and attack everyone in sight?", said Jennifer.

"Not quite, cause they're not attacking everyone. They are only attacking uninfected people.", supplied Matthias.

"Exactly, and here, look-", Woods opened a post on r/apocalypse on Reddit, "Some people think the infected can sense each other through some sort of hivemind thing or by smell or whatever, and therefore they know who to go after.", said Woods while scrolling through the comments on the reddit post. Matthias' phone started ringing.

"It's Chrissy.", said Matthias, relieved.

"Hurry and pick it up then.", said Jennifer and gestured for Matthias to pick up the phone. He quickly put the phone up to his ear and walked out of the room. Woods was now scrolling through Twitter under the hashtag: 'WorldIsOverParty'.

"Look at all these videos. It's all over the world.", said Woods while scrolling through tons of videos under the hashtag. Jennifer wrapped her arms around Woods sitting in the chair.

"I am so glad you both were home visiting when all of this started.", Jennifer hugged Woods tighter, "Your old mother would have been worried to death.", continued Jennifer.

"Me too, mom. It's gonna be okay, we're here to protect you.", said Woods while padding Jennifer's shoulder.

"I gotta go.", said Matthias while bursting into the room. Jennifer let go of Woods and quickly turned to Matthias.

"Absolutely not, Matthias. You're not going out there.", said Jennifer and gave him a stern look.

"I'm sorry, I have to, mom, it's urgent. Someone's trying to break into Chrissy's house.", Matthias pulled car keys out of his pocket, "I'll hurry. Take care of mom, lil' bro.", said Matthias and quickly ran out of the room before Woods could respond.

“Matthias Nash, you stop right now! You are not leav-”, said Jennifer before being interrupted by the front door slamming shut. Jennifer shook her head.

“Jesus Christ, that boy. He's just like your father. Reckless and stupid.”, Jennifer turned around to face Woods, “I’m glad you didn’t inherit that as well.”, said Jennifer and smiled at Woods. Woods' heart was beating fast and his breathing got heavy. He was worried about Matthias.

“Yeah… uhm- how far away does Chrissy live?”, asked Woods, trying not to look as he felt.

“Luckily not too far away. She moved just outside of town last month.”, Jennifer suddenly looked like she was about to fall so Woods quickly stood up and helped her sit down, “Phew, I suddenly felt dizzy.”, said Jennifer and took a deep breath.

“Are you- are you okay? Do you need water or anything?”, said Woods worryingly while trying to examine her eyes.

“Yes, I’m okay, Woodland. Water would be good, thanks. I think it’s just the MS.”, said Jennifer while looking up at the ceiling and taking deep breaths.

“Hang tight, I’ll get some.”, said Woods as he made his way into the kitchen with a brisk pace. He grabbed a glass and turned the valve to the sink but quickly let go of the glass in shock as a brown liquid came out of the faucet.

“What the fuck?”, muttered Woods as he studied the brown liquid running out of the sink. How could the water already be contaminated? The city’s water system should still be functional. It had only been two days since the broadcast began - then it occurred to Woods. The outbreak must have started long before the broadcast. Suddenly, the sound of something hitting the ground came from inside the room where his mother was.

“Mom! Mom, are you okay!?”, yelled Woods as he ran into the room. Jennifer was lying on the ground with her back to Woods, shaking. Woods hastily crouched down to Jennifer and turned her towards him. His eyes widened in fear as he saw foam coming out of her mouth. It was the exact same thing he had seen earlier that day on Discord. Someone had posted a video, showing what happened when someone got infected. It was the exact same thing.

“Mom, mom, mom, mom! Hey-hey! Mom. Can you hear me? Mom!”, said Woods in a shivering voice while grabbing her shoulders and shaking her. He began to fear the worst.

“No-no-no-no, please don’t, mom! Mom, wake up!”, said Woods. Then he remembered how to be sure about whether or not she was what he thought she was. He was hesitant but after pulling himself together, he pulled open her closed eyelids. When he saw the gray pupils, he let go instantly and moved back against the wall.

“No-no, God, no. It can’t- you-you can’t… How would you even?... It doesn’t make sense… ”, said Woods to himself while trying to come to terms with the fact that she was infected. Tears ran down his face. Before he could process everything, he heard the front door fling open and slam into the wall.

“Mom! Woods!”, yelled Matthias as he came running into the room. He looked in shock at the horrifying scene in front of him. His mom lying on the ground, shaking and foaming at her mouth and his brother sitting next to her, just staring at her.

“Oh fuck.”, Matthias stared at their mom for a while, “Woods, we gotta go.”, said Matthias commandingly and put his hand on Woods’ shoulder. Woods looked up at Matthias with confusion but then saw that he was covered in blood and changed his expression immediately. Matthias’ eyes were filled with sorrow and fear combined, making Woods’ heart beat even faster.

“She’s gone.”, Matthias looked deep into Woods’ eyes, “We gotta go.”, whispered Matthias and gave Woods an understanding but also commanding look. Woods nodded and stood up slowly, following Matthias as he ran outside. Woods had been so mesmerized by the fear from seeing his mom lying on the ground dying, that he hadn’t noticed how chaotic it sounded in the neighborhood. It was pandemonium. People were screaming, guns were being fired and even more sirens were blaring. He looked around as he followed Matthias into his car. It felt like everything was going in slow motion. He saw bodies lying on the street, houses burning and cars crashed. The car engine loudly revved and Matthias pulled out of the driveway.

“What happened? Whe-where’s Chrissy?”, asked Woods and looked at Matthias. He could see Matthias tightening his grip around the steering wheel.

“She was infected.”, said Matthias and kept his eyes glued to the road.

“I’m sorry, Mathias.”, Woods exhaled and laid his head back on the headrest, “This is insane. What the fuck is happening?”, whispered Woods and closed his eyes. He tried to slow down his breathing.

“A world-wide massacre.”, said Matthias. Woods opened his eyes again and looked at Matthias. He looked back at him.

“One we will survive. Together. Dad prepared us for this.”, continued Matthias and looked back at the road.

Woods woke up covered in his own sweat. He had fallen asleep in his clothes. The air was warm and the temperature humid, inside of the 3-room bunker where he and Matthias had been staying ever since they left their hometown. Their father had been a doomsday prepper since his teenage years, so he had always put money aside to buy a bunker. It was the only thing he wrote in his will for them to have. Their whole family had always thought that he was crazy - until now.

“Here.”, Matthias walked into the room Woods slept in and threw a Hawaiian t-shirt and a pair of blue shorts to him, “Found it in my room, thought maybe you would like a new set of clothes.”, said Matthias. Woods caught the clothes and examined them.

“Thanks. I don’t think it’s my size though.”, said Woods as he tried the shirt on.

“Oh I’m so sorry, sir, I’ll go in the back and see if I can find one in your size. You’re a medium right?”, said Matthias and pointed at Woods with a smirk on his face.

“Ha-ha, funny.”, Woods put on the shorts, “It’s fine. I’ll manage.”, said Woods and walked out of the room with Matthias. In the middle of the room was a table with a map folded out on it. They both sat down by it.

“Okay so look-”, Matthias pointed at a place named: ‘Copenville’ on the map, “This is the closest town to us and if I remember correctly, the car had half-a-tank on it when we got here, so we should be able to make it there and back.”, said Matthias.

“Perfect, I know where we can find a supermarket there.”, said Woods.

“Great. Let’s go then.”, said Matthias and grabbed a pair of car keys from the table.

“But wait-wait, what if it has already been looted?”, asked Woods. Matthias sat still and thought about it for a brief moment.

“Then we hopefully find some gas there, drive back, survive on water one more day and go to another town.”, said Matthias and looked at Woods. Woods nodded.

“Hey, remember, we just have to survive a couple more days. Then the army should have Charleston secured, right? That’s what they said?”, asked Matthias and pointed to a radio in the corner of the room.

“Yeah, they said like, three to four days.”, said Woods while nodding.

“Perfect. That’s soon, bro. We’ll be in safe hands soon.”, said Matthias and smiled at Woods. He smiled back reluctantly.

A billboard saying: ‘Copenville’ in different colored letters, stood in front of Woods and Matthias. They had parked their car just out of town.

“Alright.”, Matthias handed Woods a handgun, “You lead.”, said Matthias and gestured with his head for Woods to move. Woods studied the gun. He pulled out the magazine, loaded it back in and cocked the gun.

“And we thought the old man was crazy, huh? All that firearm and survival training.”, Matthias chuckled, “But he was right all along. I really wish he wasn’t.”, said Matthias and looked down at the ground.

“Yeah… me too.”, said Woods and began to walk towards the city. Matthias followed behind.

The brothers walked through a suburban neighborhood. Some houses were in decent condition meanwhile others were completely destroyed. Trash littered the streets and the only sounds that could be heard were their footsteps and the wind passing through the trees and houses. After walking for a couple of minutes, they heard a car driving in the distance. They both stopped moving and listened. The sound got closer and closer. Matthias whistled at Woods to signal for him to follow him. They ran to the porch of one of the houses on the street and hid behind a fence. The car slowly drove past them and continued down the street. It was a man driving the car.

“What do we do?”, asked Woods in a whisper.

“We follow him.”, said Matthias. Woods gave Matthias a confused look.

"*What?* Remember what they said on the radio, some people-", said Woods before being interrupted by Matthias.

"I know. We follow him to see whether or not he's friendly.", said Matthias and stood up. Woods hesitantly followed suit.

They followed the man while staying hidden as he drove through the suburban neighborhood. Eventually, the man stopped the car and got out. He had a shotgun wrapped around his body with a strap. He pulled open the door to the backseat and took out a gas can. He then looked around and stared at something in the sky for a while before locking the car doors and moving towards the center of the city.

"We could use that gas can.", whispered Woods.

"Yeah, I know. The guy's carrying a heavy duty shotgun though, so I'm not sure he's the type of guy to let other people borrow it.", said Matthias.

"Yeah, you're right.", said Woods. They followed him all the way into the town meanwhile staying hidden and keeping their distance. Suddenly, the man stopped in the middle of the street, standing in the middle of multiple bodies on the ground. He then looked at one of the buildings around him. Woods and Matthias sat crouched behind a bus stop on the sidewalk.

"Hey, look-", Woods pointed at the building which the man was looking at, "That's the supermarket I was talking about.", whispered Woods. Matthias didn't respond. He was squinting his eyes, trying to see why the man had stopped.

"What the fuck is he doin-", said Matthias as he saw the man pull out his shotgun and aim at the ground. Before he could finish his sentence, the man pulled the trigger. Matthias and Woods both got jumpscared by the blast and looked with confusion. The man turned his head and looked down the street, towards them. Matthias could just barely make it out but saw panic in his expression. He then panicked himself. But before he could react any further, growling and multiple footsteps could be heard all around them.

"That fucking idiot.", whispered Matthias while they watched the man run into a building. Matthias cocked his handgun as he saw infected come running out of the building from across the street.

"Shit, Matthias!", yelled Woods as four infected also came running out from the building right next to them. Matthias turned away from the ones across the street and shot two of the infected closest to them while Woods shot the other two. Before Matthias could turn around again, he got tackled by one behind him. He fell to the ground on his stomach and dropped the handgun. Woods turned around as soon as he heard him get tackled but it was too late. Woods stood still as he witnessed the infected biting into Matthias shoulder. His heart sank. He felt like everything was moving in slow motion once again. He saw it but he wouldn't believe it. He wouldn't believe that he just lost the last of his family. But then time started catching up again and Woods pulled himself together, aimed and shot the infected in the head. As Matthias tried to stand up, Woods became filled with rage. He aimed at another one. Headshot. Another one. Headshot. And another one. Headshot. But more were coming towards them further down the street. It wasn't long before they would be surrounded by too many. Woods turned to Matthias

who sat with his back against the bus stop, holding onto the bit shoulder. He crouched down in front of him.

“Matthias, you-you’re gonna be okay. Alright? We-we’ll-we’ll get to the, uhh- they-they probably have a cure at the- the-the army probably has a cure. Just-just don’t… don’t leave me please.”, said Woods as he began to choke up and water filled his eyes. Matthias sat with his head up against the bus stop, looking up at the sky.

“We both know it’s over for me, Woods.”, tears ran down from Matthias’ eyes, “You know, I’ve always tried to stay strong for you. Show no fear. So you wouldn’t be scared. But Woods… now I’m scared. So I need you to stay strong for me.”, said Matthias. Woods looked as the gray began to overtake his eyes.

“Please… Matthias, please don’t… don’t leave me. I can’t… I don’t- I don’t know what to do… I can’t do this without you brother, please…”, sobbed Woods as the tears kept running.

“Woodland.”, Matthias grabbed Woods’ arm tightly, “I can feel it. Taking over. It’s painful, Woods. Please. Promise me, brother. Promise me you won’t end up like this. Carry on our family. Stay strong, Woodland. For me.”, said Matthias with blank gray eyes, his body began to shake.

“I… I-I-I promise. I promise.”, said Woods with a choked speech. The infected were almost there.

“Good.”, said Matthias before his body slowly went limp and fell to the side. Woods sat still for a while. Matthias' body began to move and a low growling came out of his reawakened body. Woods then wiped the tears off his face, stood up and aimed his handgun at his brother.

“I promise.”

Chapter VIII

A Helping Hand

12-04-2030

"I'm sorry to hear that.", Jay gave Woods a compassionate look, "I know how it feels to lose your family. You don't ever really get over it, but… eventually, you'll learn to live with it.", said Jay. Woods had told Jay about what he had gone through before they met. They were sitting on the roof of the building next to the bar. They had pulled the ladder off of the trapdoor and placed it between the roof of the two buildings. After making their way across the ladder, they pushed it off and decided to wait for the infected to leave. The infected couldn't get to them but they were stuck on the roof, so all they could do was wait for the infected to get distracted by something else or give up. All they could do was hope.

"It's just- I-I can't… I can't comprehend they're gone. I can't comprehend any of this. Everything's happening so fast. Without my brother, I'm-I'm lost.", said Woods and placed his hands on his forehead while looking down at the ground.

"Yeah, I get that. I can't imagine losing your family that way. In hindsight, I guess I was lucky.", said Jay, which made Woods look up at him.

"What happened to yours?", asked Woods with an inquisitive expression. Jay locked eyes with Woods for a brief second but then looked away and sighed.

"I lost my parents when I was fifteen. They were just going to visit family one day and then, they never came back again. Some stupid fucking drunk pilot. They were in the air for no more than twenty minutes.", Jay paused, "I know how you feel, Woods. You don't ever get over it, but… you learn to live with it. Eventually.", said Jay and looked back at Woods.

"I'm so sorry to hear that, Jay. That's… I'm sorry.", Woods looked out at the infected on the street, "But don't call that lucky. All death is equally terrible.", said Woods and looked back at Jay. Jay shook his head.

"No Woods, it's not. That I know with one-hundred percent certainty.", said Jay. Before Woods could respond, they heard a gunshot close-by. Both of their heads turned immediately towards the direction of the sound. Then three more gunshots got fired and they both stood up and went to the edge of the roof. All the infected turned their attention to the direction of the gunshots and instantly ran towards it. Jay felt relieved.

"Let's go. Quick.", said Jay and gestured with his head for Woods to follow. The shooting continued as they climbed down from the roof.

"This way, I've got a car not far from here.", said Jay but then saw Woods looking at the direction of the gunshots. Jay knew why.

"Woods, we can't. There's way too many.", said Jay and pulled out his shotgun. Woods kept staring.

"Exactly. That's why we have to help them.", said Woods, causing Jay to sigh and roll his eyes.

“It’s not the fucking time to play hero, okay? Remember what you promised your brother.”, said Jay which made Woods turn to look at Jay immediately.

“You don’t know anything about my brother.”, said Woods. His eyebrows scrunched together.

“That’s right, I don’t. But I know what you told me and he wanted you to promise to stay alive, not go get yourself killed.”, said Jay with an emotionless tone.

“Yes, and I’m only able to keep that promise because you saved me. So I’m gonna help someone else keep their promise as well. I know my brother would have wanted that.”, said Woods and pulled out his handgun. He then ran towards the gunshots. Jay stood still, looking between the empty road and Woods. He contemplated what to do for a couple of seconds.

“Goddamit.”, muttered Jay and ran after Woods.

Woods was significantly faster than Jay, so it was hard for him to catch up. Though eventually, Woods stopped and Jay ran up beside him. In front of them stood a woman on top of a semi-truck which had crashed into a building on the street. Equipped with a handgun and a bowie knife, she shot and stabbed the infected as they tried to make their way up to her. The woman had pigtail hair buns and was wearing a black tank-top, camo green cargo pants, a holster shoulder harness and a military grade backpack. Woods began to shoot at the infected and yelled at them to draw their attention. The woman looked at Jay and Woods with scrunched eyebrows and as the infected turned their attention to them, she jumped down from the semi-truck and ran away.

“Wa-wait! We’re-we’re here to help you!”, yelled Woods but the woman kept running. Jay shook his head at Woods.

“You just had to play hero, huh?”, said Jay and aimed his shotgun at the infected coming their way. He blasted one, cocked his shotgun and blasted another. As he and Woods shot at them, he noticed more running out from the buildings on the street. He shot two more and then heard the sound he dreaded. He was out of ammo. He threw the shotgun over his shoulder and pulled out his hatchet.

“Cover me.”, said Jay, giving Woods a trusting look. Jay ran up to two infected, thrusting the hatchet into the skull of one of them while grabbing the shirt of the other and throwing it to the ground. He quickly pulled out the hatchet of the skull, turned around and placed the hatchet deep in the head of the one on the ground. As he had his back turned to the nearing horde of infected, one had gotten close and was just about to get Jay before Woods shot it in the chest and thereafter the head. Jay turned around as the infected fell to the ground and then turned his head to Woods, giving him a nod of respect. Woods nodded back and Jay pulled out the hatchet. There were twelve infected running at them - too many for two people.

“Shit, I’m out of ammo. What do we do?”, asked Woods and looked at Jay with panic in his eyes.

“No worries.”, Jay threw his hatchet to Woods and pulled out his kitchen knife, “We’ll get up close and personal then.”, said Jay and readied his knife as the infected got closer.

“I-I-I can’t- I-I’ve only used guns to fight them.”, said Woods with a shaky voice as he put the gun in his belt and picked up the hatchet. Jay turned to Woods.

“Time for you to learn then.”, said Jay and slowly walked towards the infected. Woods stood back in fear while tightly holding onto the hatchet.

“Get down!”, yelled a voice. Jay was confused for a second before noticing the woman from earlier standing down the street with a MP5. Jay looked back at Woods and saw him standing frozen in fear. A quick flash of when he stood frozen himself while Chris got attacked popped into his head. He quickly ran to Woods and tackled him to the ground right before the woman started shooting. Bullets penetrated every part of the infected, killing each and every single one of them. As the last infected fell to the ground, the shooting stopped. Jay slowly stood up again and put his hand out to help Woods get up.

“I think I’ll just lay here for a second.”, said Woods with a winded voice. He had gotten the wind knocked out of him from Jay landing on top of him. Jay pulled his hand back and turned towards the woman.

“Thanks.”, said Jay in a loud voice as they were standing far apart. The woman began to walk towards Jay and Woods.

“Ditto.”, said the woman and stretched while she made her way towards them. Jay looked at her with suspicion as she got closer.

“Is he alright?”, asked the woman and pointed to Woods who was still trying to recover. He gave a thumbs up while Jay looked suspiciously at the MP5.

“How’d you get your hands on that?”, asked Jay and pointed to the MP5 with his head. The woman could sense something weird about Jay’s tone.

“What does it matter to you?”, said the woman and lifted her eyebrows. Jay smiled at her.

“Just wondering.”, said Jay while lifting his shoulder up a slight bit. They stood in silence for a moment, staring each other down.

“I found it.”, said the woman with confidence. Jay became more suspicious of her.

“Where? In a school bus?”, joked Jay with a hint of smirk.

“In a crashed military van.”, said the woman. They both looked at each other with suspicion.

“Hm. Lucky.”, said Jay and kept his suspicious expression. Meanwhile they stared at each other, Woods slowly grunted his way up from the ground.

“Hi.”, Woods stuck his hand out, “I’m Woodland, or-or just call me Woods. And this is uhh- this is Jay.”, Woods pointed at Jay, “Thanks for coming back and saving us.”, said Woods and smiled at the woman. She kept her eyes locked with Jay for a couple of seconds before turning to Woods.

“No problem, Woods.”, the woman holstered the MP5 in her shoulder harness, “Anyways, I better get going. Good luck out there.”, said the woman and started walking away. Woods put his hand down as she left him hanging.

“Wa-wa-wait! Why? W-we-we can stick together, right?”, Woods turned to Jay, “Right?”, asked Woods with an inquisitive expression on his face.

“She wants to go alone, Woods.”, said Jay in a low voice and crouched down, pulling out a bottle of water and washing his bloody hands. Woods looked at Jay with confusion. He then turned to the woman again.

“Wait, listen, I know where the military is held up. I can get us to safety!”, yelled Woods to the woman which made her stop moving. Jay stopped as well and looked up at Woods.

“What?”, Jay stood up, “How do you know that?”, asked Jay. His heartbeat began to ramp up. Woods turned to Jay.

“I-I-I heard it in the- in the-the radio. When I was down in the bunker with my brother.”, Woods turned back to the woman, “They’re making a safe zone in Charleston. It’s ready in uhh- I-I think it was two or three days. We can go there together.”, said Woods. Jay stood with his mouth open in disbelief. He then chuckled.

“You’re full of surprises, man.”, said Jay and smiled at Woods. The woman turned around and walked up close to Woods.

“How do I get there?”, asked the woman with a serious look in her eyes. Woods backed up a bit while looking back and forth between the woman and Jay.

“Well uhh- I uhh- I-I-I know the way. But-but I can’t really explain it. I-I don’t have a map to show you.”, said Woods nervously. The woman looked away. Jay stared at her with suspicion meanwhile.

“How long?”, asked the woman and looked back at Woods.

“Uhh- like, what? How many kilometers or like-”, Jay interrupted Woods, “Time, Woods. How long is it gonna take.”, said Jay.

“Like uhh- I-I think eight hours by car. Seven days on foot.”, said Woods while looking back at the woman who stared at him emotionlessly. The woman turned her attention to Jay.

“Do you have a car?”, asked the woman while keeping the same emotionless look.

“Yeah. Not too far from here. I’m out of fuel though and I lost my gas can.”, said Jay in a matching tone to the woman’s.

“I-I have a car as well. Just outside of the city. It-it has a little bit of fuel on it, so we can get a quarter of the way I think.”, said Woods while looking back and forth between them.

“We take his car then.”, said the woman.

“Sure, let’s go.”, said Jay and put the bottle of water back in his backpack. They stood still. The woman and Jay both looked at Woods who just stood smiling. Jay then gestured with his hand for Woods to lead the way.

“Oh yeah, sorry-sorry.”, said Woods and began walking. Jay walked alongside Woods meanwhile the woman followed a couple of meters behind them. After walking for a bit, Woods turned his head, looking back at the woman while walking.

“So uhh- wha-what’s uh- what’s your name? You didn’t say.”, asked Woods and smiled at the woman. She was walking with her head pointed downward.

“Miyahara Megumi.”, Jay’s eyes widened when he heard the name, “But it’s probably easier for you to call me Miya.”, said Miya and looked up at Woods.

“Nice to meet you, Miya. My-my full name’s Woodland Nash by the way. I uhh- I-I-I felt like I had to say that since you said yours.”, said Woods while keeping his quirky smile. Miya smiled slightly and then turned her head down again. Woods kept smiling and then turned his head forward. Jay’s breathing had gotten heavy and he looked as if he was thinking about something very extensively. Woods turned to Jay.

“Hey, uhh- Jay.”, said Woods. Jay tried to calm his breath down and look as if his mind wasn’t racing.

“Yeah, Woods?”, said Jay.

“You uhh- earlier, you uhh- you-you said that you knew with certainty that- that all death isn’t equally terrible? What did you mean by- like, how do you know?”, asked Woods. Jay looked at Woods with a serious expression.

“I know because I’ve experienced a lot of it. Even before all of this started.”, Miya looked up at Jay with pitiful eyes, “I know for a fact that one death can be more tolerable than another.”, said Jay and looked away while fiddling with the cross pendant necklace. Woods matched Miya’s expression after Jay stopped talking. Woods then remembered what his brother told him before he died which made him relate to Jay more than before. He was doing what Woods’ brother had told Woods to do. What you had to do in the face of constant death and suffering. He was staying strong.

Jay, Woods and Miya had made it to the car and were driving down the road, making their way to Charleston. They sat in silence. Woods was driving, Jay sat in the passenger seat and Miya was in the middle backseat. She was cleaning her MP5 thoroughly with a piece of cloth. Jay turned the rearview mirror and looked at Miya through it.

“So, how are you so experienced with firearms?”, asked Jay and made eye contact with Miya through the mirror as she looked up. She had a deadpan expression on her face.

“Why do you care?”, asked Miya with a confrontational and defensive tone. Jay chuckled slightly.

“I’m just curious-”, said Jay before being cut off by Miya.

“You’re not just curious. I can hear it in your voice. You didn’t ask how I got this out of curiosity either. You’re asking for a reason.”, said Miya with an emotional expression. Jay sighed.

“What other reason would there be?”, said Jay with a confused expression.

“I don’t know. You tell me.”, said Miya and lifted her eyebrows, awaiting Jay’s response. They stared at each other through the mirror for a while. Woods’ started getting nervous and kept looking back and forth between the road and Jay.

“Heh, I don’t know what to tell you. There’s no ulterior motive. It’s just not everyday you see a girl who knows how to handle firearms, especially SMG’s.”, said Jay, to which Miya responded as soon as he finished the sentence.

“Oh, so you’re sexist? That’s why?”, asked Miya with a sassy tone in her voice and tilted her head slightly. Jay sighed and shook his head.

“Okay forget the girl part. It’s just not a normal sight. Period.”, Jay pointed to Woods, “Like, Woods and I, for example, we don’t know how.”, said Jay, to which Woods instantly responded.

“Actually I uhh- I-I do.”, said Woods, lifting his finger and looking back at Jay. Jay scrunched his eyebrows in confusion.

“What? You do?”, asked Jay and kept the same expression.

“Yeah, uh, my-my uhh- my-my dad was a doomsday prepper, so he uhh- he-he taught my brother and I how to use firearms when we turned 16, so…”, said Woods while looking back and forth between the road and Jay. Jay let out a hmph.

“So your dad predicted all of this, huh?”, said Jay.

“Well uhh- not-not-not really, he-he uhh- he thought demons from hell would one day come to earth and try to eradicate humans.”, said Woods and stopped looking back at Jay and instead kept his eyes forward.

“Well, that still could happen. Considering all of this shit going on, I wouldn’t dismiss it.”, said Jay. Woods nodded.

“Yeah, maybe.”, said Woods. Jay looked back up at the rearview mirror.

“See, he just explained how he knew without getting defensive. Why can’t you?”, asked Jay with an inquisitive look. Miya stopped cleaning the MP5 and looked up at Jay. They stared at each other in silence for a moment before Miya looked down at her MP5 again.

“My dad taught me.”, said Miya and continued to clean her MP5. Jay kept looking at Miya.

“He was in the military?”, asked Jay which made Miya look up at Jay.

“Is. He is in the military.”, said Miya and thereafter looked back down at her MP5 again. Jay kept staring at Miya.

“Now I get it. It’s going to be a family reunion when we get there, isn’t it?”, asked Jay. Miya kept her eyes glued to the MP5 but stopped cleaning.

“That’s what I hope.”, said Miya in a low voice. Woods looked at Jay and gave him a look of compassion. Jay nodded at Woods.

“Well, I’m glad we can help you, hopefully, find him.”, said Jay and gave Miya a compassionate look. She was still looking at the MP5. It was silent for a while. Woods sat uneasy because of the silence and kept fidgeting with the wheel. He turned the rearview mirror so he could see Miya.

“If uhh- you know if uhh- if-if he’s from the military, he’s probably a badass right? So uhh- I-I’m sure he’s okay.”, said Woods and smiled at Miya through the mirror. She looked up at him and smiled slightly. Jay turned his head and looked out the passenger window. He tightened his jaw and his breathing got heavy. Each of his thumbs cracked as he made a fist and pressed against them. He was filled with rage.

Chapter IX

The Megumi Family

14-03-2030

“Ma’am, you have to go with us. It’s your husband's orders.”, said a man carrying a SMG and dressed in a military outfit. On the road behind him was a combat vehicle with two other military personnel standing in front of it. SMGs in hand. He was standing in the doorway of the Megumi family’s property. In front of him stood Miyahara Megumi, Yamada Megumi and Miyata Megumi.

“You tell him to get here and explain. We’re not leaving without knowing why.”, said Yamada Megumi.

“Ma’am, it’s an urgent matter. We were commanded not to tell you. He will explain once you get there.”, said the military officer.

“No. He comes here and explains or we stay.”, said Yamada with conviction. The officer sighed and gestured with two fingers for them to wait. He then walked to the vehicle and grabbed the radio attached to his chest.

“Sir, your wife won’t leave without an explanation or you present.”, said the officer.

“Tell her Kano is with me. That should convince her to go.”, said Ozawa Megumi.

“Yes sir.”, said the officer and slowly walked back to the door.

“Your husband wanted me to tell you that Kano is there with him.”, said the officer reluctantly. Yamada stood in silence for a bit before turning to Miya and Miyata

“Go get your stuff.”, said Yamada. Miya and Miyata went into the living room to get their stuff.

“I apologize for forcing you, Mrs. Megumi.”, said the officer and gave Yamada a compassionate look.

“You’re not, William. My husband is.”, said Yamada. The officer nodded and walked back to the vehicle. Miya and Miyata came back with their suitcases in hand. Miyata grabbed Yamada’s arm.

“Mom, why is dad doing this? What’s going on?”, asked Miyata with worry. Yamada kept her eyes looking forward.

“I don’t know, Miyata, but your father knows best. We have to go with them.”, said Yamada and walked to the vehicle. Miya and Miyata looked at each other with worry but did as their mother said.

“Sorry to ask mam, but don’t you want to bring some things as well?”, asked the officer. Yamada looked at the officer with suspicion.

“I expect to be back home again soon. So I’ll be okay.”, said Yamada and crawled into the backseat with Miya and Miyata. The officer stood still while staring at the Megumi residence.

“Sir?”, said one of the soldiers. The officer took a deep breath and turned around to look at him.

“Yes, let’s go.”, said the officer and got into the vehicle. The soldier started the engine and they drove off.

It had been two hours since they left the Megumi residence and they were now driving through a dense forest. When another hour passed, a military outpost could be seen. Miya studied the outpost as they drove down a hill, giving her a clear view of the place. It was formed like a rectangle with the dense forest surrounding it. The perimeter of the outpost was made out of HESCO barriers stacked on top of each other. Inside of the protected area were four tents, a steel-made modular two-story building, one 6x6 cargo truck, tall spotlights, portable generators and a radio tower in the middle of everything. Built in each of the corners were also small wooden watchtowers occupied by soldiers equipped with snipers. It made Miya worried but she quickly put that worry aside. As they got closer, she noticed logs stacked on both sides of the entrance which was covered by a metal fence the soldiers had to move to let the vehicle in. When the vehicle turned off, the officer and two soldiers got out and so did Miya, Miyata and Yamada.

“Please allow me to escort you to General Megumi. Private Anderson and Corporal Hersh will take care of your luggage.”, said the officer and led them to the modular two-story building which was built by two containers on top of each other connected with stairs on the outside. As they walked up the stairs and Miya looked out at the outpost, it occurred to her that they weren’t going to be leaving anytime soon. The soldiers in the camp were hastily walking around, carrying boxes into tents, connecting wires to the spotlights and fortifying the barriers. She realized that the outpost had been built recently and that it was being built to last. To protect. But from what? Before she could give it any more thought, the officer opened the door to the second floor and gestured for them to go in. Inside was a round table with six chairs around it, a kitchen counter and a door leading to another room.

“Take a seat while I inform General Megumi of your arrival.”, said the officer and went into the other room. Miya and Miyata immediately looked at Yamada when the door closed.

“Mom, what is all this? What are they building this place for?”, asked Miya.

“And more importantly, why are *we* here?”, added Miyata. Their mother was looking at the door to the other room and didn’t respond for a couple of seconds.

“I’m sure your father has a very good reason.”, said Yamada while staring at the door. Miya and Miyata gave each other a confused look.

“Mom, this is insane. Dad can’t just abuse his power like this. They literally showed up at Tim’s party and almost dragged me out of there. This is not okay.”, said Miyata and tried to make eye contact with Yamada but she had her eyes glued to the door. Suddenly, someone running up the outer stairs could be heard followed by the door being flung open. They all turned to the door in shock.

“What’s up, my oh-so beloved family?”, said Kano Megumi who stood in the door dressed in gray joggers, a hoodie and a baseball cap. He grabbed one of the chairs, turned it around and sat down, placing crossed arms on top of the back of it while looking at them with a

huge smile. Miya and Miyata rolled their eyes at the sight of their brother while Yamada turned her gaze back to the door.

"Isn't this place fucking great?", asked Kano sarcastically.

"Language.", said Yamada and turned to Kano with a stern look on her face.

"Oh, you acknowledged me, mom? That's new.", said Kano with a smirk on his face. Yamada turned back to look at the door.

"Can you stop being annoying for once in your life?", asked Miyata.

"No can do, sis.", said Kano and stood up, walking over to the kitchen sink. Miyata shook her head in annoyance.

"Do you know what's going on, Kano?", asked Miya while Kano filled a glass with water.

"Other than dad being a control freak and abusing his power like usual? Nope.", said Kano and downed the glass of water.

"Don't talk about your dad that way.", said Yamada with anger in her voice while looking at Kano.

"Still as submissive as ever.", said Kano before the door opened and the officer walked out followed by Ozawa Megumi. His presence made the room go silent, attracting everyone's attention. Kano clumsily and hastily put the glass down on the counter and straightened his posture. Ozawa gave Kano a disappointing look.

"Didn't I tell you to change into something respectable?", asked Ozawa while digging deep into his soul with his eyes of immense disappointment.

"Yeah uhh- I-I just uhh- I wanted to-to uhh- say hi to mom and… and uhh…", Kano's speech faded out, "I'm sorry dad, I'll go change.", said Kano and swiftly made his way out of the room. Ozawa looked at the Officer.

"Go make sure he changes into the right size.", commanded Ozawa. The officer nodded and followed Kano.

"Has Officer Jones treated you well?", asked Ozawa emotionless.

"He always does, dear.", said Yamada and walked over to Ozawa. She grabbed his hand and wrapped it with both of her hands while smiling at him. They smiled at each other for a brief moment and then let go of each other's hands.

"I don't know what's going on here, dad, but I know I'm twenty-nine which makes me an adult. And that means you can't just have people come and force me to go somewhere against my will. And I'm also pretty sure that's illegal.", said Miyata with frustration in her voice.

"I wouldn't do it if it wasn't necessary, Miyata.", said Ozawa.

"Okay, explain then, dad. Because it doesn't feel necessary.", said Miyata, still frustrated with her father. Ozawa sighed.

"I've brought you here to protect you.", said Ozawa, sounding slightly frustrated.

"From what?", said Miyata. Ozawa started getting impatient.

"I'll explain later, Miyata", said Ozawa, growing more frustrated and impatient with Miyata.

“No, you’ll explain now, dad.”, commanded Miyata. Miya noticed her father’s growing frustration.

“I said, I will explain later.”, said Ozawa trying to keep his cool. Miya then noticed something else.

“If you don’t explain it right now, I will leave.”, commanded Miyata.

“You can’t leave.”, said Ozawa, almost losing his cool.

“Why not?”, asked Miyata.

“Listen to your father, Miyata.”, said Yamada as a way to diffuse the situation.

“No, mom, what the hell’s wrong with you?”, said Miyata.

“Language, Miyata.”, said Yamada while lifting her finger.

“No, piss off with your ‘language’ right now. Earlier you demanded an explanation and now you’re just doing what he says? Why?”, said Miyata, filled with frustration.

“I trust your dad is doing this for a good reason.”, said Yamada calmly which frustrated Miyata even more.

“Well, I don’t. I’m giving you one last chance, dad, and then I’m leaving.”, said Miyata, being fed up with her parents.

“*Stop it, Miyata!*”, yelled Ozawa, making the whole room go silent. Ozawa’s outburst left him breathing heavily and the veins in his forehead looked as if they were about to burst. Miya didn’t want to believe what she had noticed was true. But it was. Her father was afraid.

“You’re afraid. Why are you afraid, dad?”, asked Miya, looking at her father with worry. He turned to her, still breathing heavily, and then turning back to look at Miyata.

“You can’t. Leave.”, said Ozawa in a quiet but commanding voice. Miyata’s frustration was slowly taken over by worry.

“Okay, fine, I won’t. But you have to explain why, dad. If you’re afraid, we know it’s something bad and we won’t be able to feel safe until you tell us what it is.”, said Miyata. Ozawa didn’t respond.

“I get it, dad. You don’t want us to be afraid, but it’s more frightening not to know what it is. We’re not your little girls anymore, we can take it.”, said Miya. Ozawa turned to her and thereafter to Yamada. Yamada nodded.

“I’ll show you.”, said Ozawa and opened the door to the other room. It was his office. Inside stood a wide table pointing towards the door. In front of it were two chairs and behind it was a black leather-cushioned office chair, two metal cupboards and a flag. On the walls hang diplomas and medals which Ozawa had received throughout his time in the military. Ozawa walked up to the table and pulled open a drawer. He picked up an unlabeled folder and pulled out a piece of paper from it.

“This right here.”, Ozawa shook the piece of paper, “This is confidential. For now. But tomorrow, we’re going to make it known to the public.”, said Ozawa. Miya, Yamada and Miyata all looked at Ozawa with confusion.

“What is it?”, asked Miya. Ozawa sat down in his office chair and sighed. It was quiet for a while as Ozawa sat and tried to figure out how to explain the situation.

“An unknown number of scientists inside, and possibly outside of Area 52, went rogue and created a deadly, mind-altering and highly contagious virus. The only reason we know this is because we managed to capture and interrogate one of them yesterday. One who was supposed to commit suicide with the rest but wasn’t able to do it. He gave us all the information we currently have on the virus. Including the information that made us realize that it’s too late to stop it, which is why you’re here.”, said Ozawa and threw the piece of paper on the table.

“You see, the scientist told us that they have been working on this virus for years. Perfecting every aspect of it - making sure it won’t fail to spread throughout the globe. The way they have done that is by making it untraceable. As it infects your whole body, you won’t feel any symptoms nor will it be detectable through any sort of analysis, test or medical hardware. But only for two weeks.”, said Ozawa before getting interrupted by a curious Miya.

“Why two weeks?”, asked Miya.

“Because by having it spread around the world undetected for two weeks, they have made sure that it has enough time to infect at least millions of people. Then once two weeks have passed, suddenly millions of people will turn and whoever hasn’t turned will either turn later, get infected or be killed by those who have turned, slowly killing every single human on earth.”, said Ozawa and paused.

“What do you mean turn? What happens to those infected?”, asked Miyata with a worried expression. Ozawa looked away.

“Once those two weeks are up you will begin to cough up blood, get a burning fever and change eye color. All in the span of five minutes. And after that, you’ll be gone. You as a person. All that’s left will be a mindless body roaming around, trying to kill every living thing it sees. And the more it spreads, the more it will evolve. He told us that the two weeks will turn to one week, then to two days, then two hours, then two minutes. Before we could get more information, he told us we had one day left before the day of reckoning and finally committed to the cause and killed himself. We immediately contacted the government, multiple federal agencies and organizations but no one took it seriously. They all chalked it up to the delusions of a cult, so they decided they would only assign a small team to investigate it further. That was yesterday which brings us to today.”, Ozawa paused and took a deep breath.

“When we learned about it yesterday, around thirty of us at Area 52 came together to make a plan if it turned out to be true. We prepared vehicles, weapons, food, materials and more and decided that we would all meet up at this location and set up a place to protect. To protect our families. Come this morning, everything went awry. All the scientist had said came true. We all saw it with our own eyes. So we went through with our plan but only half of us made it out. The other half either turned or were killed by other’s who had turned.”, Ozawa walked to the window inside of the room and looked out.

“What you see here is a fraction of what we had prepared. We lost so many good men. All in the span of minutes. So as soon as we arrived here and dropped off everything, everyone went out to get their families. Except for me. I stayed here and tried to get in contact with anyone who would be able to stop this or at least warn the public but nothing. I then tried to contact the

military of our allied countries and that's when I realized that it's too late. It's not just our country. It's everywhere. I wanted to be hopeful and believe that it was just our country but it's not. And that's why it pains me to say this, but…", Ozawa paused and turned around to look at his family.

"Nothing will be the same again. I know it's hard to believe but we've seen it. And now all we can do is do our duty and protect the people of our country and that's what we're planning to do as soon as this place is safe for you to stay in. We're sending a broadcast out to warn anyone who's still alive and thereafter we are planning to gather materials to set up safe zones for people to go to. There's a long road ahead of us but I want you to know that I will be doing everything I can to make this world safe for you again.", said Ozawa, leaning over the table with his hands on top of it, looking at his family with a somber expression. They all sat in shock for a while, trying to digest all the information they had just received. Ozawa sat down meanwhile.

"Oh my God… I gotta contact Jessica and-and-and Jim and everyone.", said Miyata and pulled her phone out of her pocket and started typing.

"They probably won't believe you so just tell them to get home and turn on their television. The broadcast should go up on every channel soon.", said Ozawa. Miyata looked up from her phone.

"We have to go help them, dad. Get them here, to safety.", said Miyata and looked back down at her phone, typing even faster than before.

"We can't, that's too dangerous. They might be infected.", said Ozawa.

"And how do we know we're not?", asked Miya and looked at Ozawa with worry. He took a deep breath as he gathered the courage to tell her.

"We don't. That's why we have to stay here for at least two weeks and see what happens.", said Ozawa in a cold and commanding manner. Miyata looked up from her phone.

"Two weeks? We can't just stay here for two weeks. What about our friends? What about the rest of our family?", asked Miyata with frustration and a slight anger.

"We can't risk it, Miyata. We're way too many people already.", said Ozawa.

"So what? You don't even know if anyone here is infected. What would it change?", said Miyata.

"Our chances of survival, Miyata. If no one here is infected we are safe and we can keep this place as a safe zone. The more people we bring, the more our chances of someone being infected and infecting more people increases.", said Ozawa.

"We can't just leave them to die out there, dad. We have a place to keep them safe.", said Miyata.

"Not yet, Miyata. This place isn't safe before we know nobody is infected. We'll go help them after. End of discussion.", said Ozawa.

"What about after? How do we make sure we don't get infected?", asked Miya.

"Yeah, how do you even get infected?", added Miyata. Ozawa looked at Yamata who gave him an affirmative look. He looked back at the girls.

"We don't know. And we can't leave before we know.", said Ozawa.

“How are you gonna find out?”, asked Miya.

“I’ve assigned Anderson and Hersh to work on it. They’re using our radios to contact anyone they can to get more information. That’s also why the broadcast isn’t out yet. We want to make sure we have gathered all the information we can to deliver to the public.”, said Ozawa.

“What if nobody knows?”, Miyata looked down at her phone and saw no one had responded to her messages, “We can’t just stay here and let our friends die while we have the resources to save them.”, said Miyata.

“I know it feels wrong and you want to keep your friends safe, Miyata. I don’t like any of this either. Your grandmother - my mother - is out there, and she’s weak and fragile. I also want to leave and make sure she’s okay, but I also know your dad is an honest man, who will do anything to protect the people he cares about and who they care about. So you have to trust that he’s doing the best thing for everyone. Both of you.”, said Yamada and grabbed her daughter’s hands. Miya nodded. Miyata looked at her mother and back at her dad.

“Okay. But promise we’re going to get them as soon as we know.”, said Miyata. Ozawa nodded slightly.

“If we know when two weeks have passed, I promise both of you, we will find your friends.”, said Ozawa. Miya nodded but inside she had already come to terms with that, if everything her father had said was true, there wouldn’t be any friends to go and get in two weeks.

Night
15-03-2030

It was in the middle of the night. Miya suddenly woke up from the sound of a gunshot and sat up straight. She looked around and noticed her sister had been awakened by it as well. They looked at each other with worry and then both noticed that their mother was nowhere to be seen. They had all gone to bed inside of Ozawa’s office, sleeping on mattresses. Their father had decided to stay up all night to manage the radios with Anderson and Hersh.

“Where’s mom?”, asked Miya with worry.

“I don’t know. Did you-did you also hear that?”, asked Miyata and gave Miya a confused look.

“Yeah, I think so. It sounded like a gunshot.”, said Miya worryingly.

“Yeah, but why would-”, said Miyata before being interrupted by another gunshot. They both immediately stood up and got dressed. Suddenly Kano burst through the door to the office.

“Are you okay?”, asked Kano with his eyes wide open and a worried expression on his face. Miya and Miyata both responded with affirmation.

“What the fuck’s going on?”, Kano noticed their mother missing, “Where the fuck is mom?”, asked Kano, looking at his sister’s with confusion and worry fused into one facial expression.

“We don’t know. Wha-what’s happening?”, asked Miyata.

“I don’t fucking know. I was just woken up by a gunshot and came in here.”, said Kano with a panicked speech. Miya ran to the window to look outside. She saw Ozawa standing outside one of the tents with a gun pointed at the entrance to it while Yamada stood behind him.

“Look!”, said Miya which caused Kano and Miyata to sprint to the window and look out as well.

“Sir, I promise you, they were all infected.”, said Corporal Axel Cawthon who stood in the entrance to the tent. Inside were the bodies of multiple people he had killed. Ozawa had his gun pointed at Axel. He was furious and distraught.

“You don’t know that, Axel.”, said Ozawa while breathing heavily. He could see blood and legs poking out from behind Axel’s body covering the entrance.

“With all due respect sir, you’re wrong. You think I would just kill my own kid and wife without being one-hundred percent certain?”, said Axel while waving around his bloody hands.

“I don’t know, Corporal. All I see is a man who has killed a bunch of innocent people.”, said Ozawa while looking at Axel with a slightly horrified look.

“Don’t look at me like that. They were *infected*, Ozawa. *You said* that this was the only solution if someone got infected, and I trust you. So I did what you ordered us to do.”, said Axel with a slight anger in his voice. Ozawa kept his gun pointed at Axel.

“How did you know, Axel?”, asked Ozawa. Axel’s expression suddenly turned sorrowful and he looked to the ground.

“My kid turned, Ozawa. He started burning up, and I thought it was just a fever but…”, Axel paused and took a deep breath, “But then the gray in his eyes came. Mia and I both knew what we had to do, and I was going to shoot him, I promise. But then she stopped me. She cried and tried to comfort him and then… then he coughed right in her face. She immediately stood up and looked at me… and I saw the gray. Slowly covering her eyes.”, Axel covered his eyes with one of his bloody hands, “And then I slit their throats.”, said Axel. Ozawa looked at Axel with an even more horrified expression.

“Why the other’s?”, asked Ozawa, tightening his grip around the gun. Axel removed his hand from his eyes which left blood around them.

“Because then I realized how you get infected and that the scientist lied about how fast you turn. Everyone in here sat in the same cargo truck as my family, sir.”, said Axel with a serious and emotionless look in his eyes.

“Go up to the kids.”, said Ozawa to Yamada who stood behind him. She didn’t respond. Ozawa turned his head slightly to look at her from the corner of his eye.

“Yamada?”, asked Ozawa while turning his head even more. Suddenly, Axel forcefully grabbed the hand out of Ozawa’s hand which caused him to turn to Axel. Right as he faced Axel again, he pointed the gun past Ozawa’s shoulder and fired. Suddenly it felt like everything went in slow motion. Dazed and with a high-pitched ringing in his ears from the gunshot, Ozawa slowly turned around while covering his right ear. On the ground behind him was Yamada’s body with a hole right in the middle of her forehead. Ozawa tried to comprehend what had just

happened, meanwhile the ringing kept going through his ears, almost feeling like it was getting louder. He looked at her lifeless body for a couple of seconds until he could hear Axel's voice faintly pass through the high-pitched ringing in his ears. He turned around and saw Axel's mouth moving but his speech was unintelligible to Ozawa. Axel was moving his hands around while speaking and Ozawa turned his attention to the gun in Axel's bloody hands. His eyes followed it as it moved around. He then looked back up at Axel, whose lips were moving, but only a faint and muffled speech was passing through Ozawa's ears. He stared at him for a while until the ringing slowly faded away and Axel stopped speaking. They stood in silence for a brief moment.

"Okay? I saved you, she was about to atta-", said Axel before Ozawa in two swift motions, pulled the gun from his hand and shot him right in the head. Axel's body immediately went limb and fell to the ground. Now that he wasn't covering the entrance anymore, Ozawa could see all the corpses inside of the tent. He stood frozen while looking at it until he heard the door of the modular building's second floor open followed by multiple and rapid footsteps on a steel surface.

"Dad!", yelled Miya while running down the stairs with Officer Jones, Corporal Hersh, Private Anderson, Kano and Miyata. While the soldiers ran to Ozawa, the remaining members of the Megumi family stopped in front of their mother's corpse. All stood in shock for a moment followed by crying. Miya and Miyata both fell to their knees, shaking their mother's body. Meanwhile Kano stood back, placed his hands behind his head and looked into the dark and cloudy sky.

"Ozawa, are you okay?", asked Jones while placing his hand on Ozawa's back.

"We gotta go. Now!", yelled Ozawa and looked Jones in the eyes with a serious and slightly enraged look. Jones immediately removed his hand and moved back a slight bit out of surprise.

"Okay. Okay. We-we-we'll pack the cars and then-", said Jones before being interrupted by Ozawa.

"Forget everything here. We get in the cars and go. I take the truck with Hersh and Anderson and you take the car with my kids.", commanded Ozawa. Jones looked at Ozawa with confusion.

"Are you sure, sir? You don't want to-", said Jones before being interrupted by Ozawa again.

"No questions, Jones. Now!", commanded Ozawa, signaled Anderson and Hersh and hastily made his way to the truck with them. Jones didn't move for a moment as he tried to digest everything that had just happened. He then placed his hands on his hips and turned around. He saw Miya, Miyata and Kano all in distress and tried to figure out a way to get them to go with him.

"I'm-I'm-I'm really sorry about your mother. But-but we have to leave this location now, okay? Your father-", said Jones which made Miyata stand up and interrupt him.

"Fuck our father! See what happens when we listen to him!", yelled Miyata at Jones and pointed to their mother's corpse.

“I-I know, but-but it wasn’t his fault. I saw it, our Corporal Alex-”, said Jones before Kano interrupted him as well.

“Shut the fuck up, William! Stop licking our dad’s asshole all the fucking time. You’re such a little pathetic suck up, man. You’re his little puppet, just doing whatever he says.”, said Kano while mimicking a hand puppeteer with his hands. Jones didn’t say anything for a while as he tried to think of a way to get them to go with him. The engine of the truck could be heard starting up.

“You’re right. I do follow his orders. Because that’s my job. But jobs are clearly not going to be a thing anymore, so I know that I don’t have to. And that’s why I’m not asking you to come with me, because that’s what your dad wants. I’m asking you, because that’s what I believe is the safest thing to do right now. It’s not safe here anymore. We have to go.”, said Jones while looking around at them, waiting for a response.

“Yeah right. Fuck off, William.”, said Kano and shook his head but then Miya stood up while wiping the last tears from her face.

“He’s right.”, said Miya which caused Kano and Miyata to look at her with confusion.

“Dad’s got you brainwashed too?”, asked Kano.

“I’m in as much pain as you guys right now. You know that. But we can’t stay here. It’s not safe. And we don’t even know where we are.”, Kano shook his head, “Mom wanted us to trust dad like she did. And even though I can’t right now, I will try to for mom. She wouldn’t want us to leave him.”, said Miya and looked at Miyata. Miyata stood up.

“No, she wouldn’t. And of course he didn’t mean for this to happen, but… we have to look out for ourselves. We can’t let dad control everything.”, Miya nodded, “Kano?”, asked Miyata.

“I can’t leave you guys, so if that’s what you’re doing.”, said Kano while lifting his hands in a defeated manner.

“It is.”, said Miyata.

“Let’s go then.”, said Kano.

They drove out of the outpost, Ozawa, Anderson and Hersh first, followed by Kano, Miya, Miyata and Jones. It was pitch black outside. The only thing lighting up the road was the headlights on the cars. After they made it out of the dense and ominous forest, they started driving down a tight dirt road. The car was shaking as they drove. Suddenly, the truck with Ozawa, Anderson and Hersh swerved to the right and off the dirt road. Jones grabbed his walkie-talkie attached to his chest.

“Ozawa!?”, yelled Jones and before the rest of them could say anything, the tires on the car popped and the car swerved as well. In a panic, while trying to regain control of the vehicle, Jones mixed up the pedals and floored the speeder. Miya noticed they were heading straight for a high voltage tower and the only thing she could say before they hit it was:

“Oh God.”

Chapter XII

A Mixed Reunion

??-04-2030

Jay, Miya and Woods walked through the abandoned and trashed neighborhood of Charleston. Glass shards as well as trash littered the streets. Very few cars occupied the streets and those few that did were either crashed into buildings or blocking doors to homes or stores. But even though the condition of the town had definitely worsened following the apocalypse, the town seemed to have been in a bad shape to begin with. Most buildings were made out of bricks but it looked as if they had been built in the 1800 century. Bricks were poking out different places in the walls and their original orange color was vaguely visible in different places as if the paint was disappearing. Jay realized that the place had been forgotten and abandoned way before the apocalypse. After a couple of minutes of walking, they saw a tall metal fence covering the street leading to the town square. They walked up to it. It was a narrow street filled with semi-tall buildings on each side of the street. The buildings had been used for apartments, stores and other various purposes. Through the fence they could see a green cargo truck parked horizontally, blocking the street, creating a closed off space between the truck and the fence.

"This is it.", said Miya and grabbed the fence, trying to pull it to the side. After not being able to pull it, she noticed it had cement blocks attached at the bottom of it.

"Are you uhh- are-are you sure? It-it looks pretty empty.", asked Woods while looking around for any sign of life on the other side of the fence.

"Yeah, this doesn't look like something made by the military. Wouldn't there be - I don't know - guards at least? People?", Jay looked around and grabbed onto his handgun, "Something's off.", said Jay.

"No, this *is* it. I recognize the truck.", Miya tried to move the fence again, "Help me move this.", said Miya. Jay let go off his handgun and grabbed the fence as well.

"If this is the place, I don't think this is how they meant for us to get in.", said Jay but helped Miya regardless. Meanwhile Jay and Miya tried pulling the fence to the side, Woods noticed something at the top of the two buildings the fence stood between.

"Uhh gu-guys…", said Woods in a quiet and trembling voice. Jay and Miya didn't respond as they kept trying to move the fence.

"St-stop mo-moving the fence.", said Woods while staring at what he had noticed. Jay heard him and turned around.

"Why? And could you help by the way?", said Jay slightly annoyed while turning around but as soon as he saw Woods' frightened expression and that he was holding his hands up, Jay immediately grabbed his handgun and pointed it up to where Woods was looking.

"Drop it.", said a girly voice as soon as Jay pointed his gun. Miya stopped moving the fence and looked up. Jay kept his gun pointed for a moment while he scanned the rooftops. On the roof of the left building sat three people with scoped rifles pointed down at them and on the

right sat one with a SMG and one with a walkie-talkie up to his mouth. After Jay had finished scanning the rooftops, he slowly put his hand up and dropped the gun while keeping them up.

“Miyata?”, said Miya. Jay and Woods both turned their gaze to Miya with confusion. It was quiet for a moment but then the girl on the roof lowered her weapon and stood up.

“Everybody put your guns down. It’s Miya.”, said Miyata. Everyone on the rooftops lowered their weapons, meanwhile the guy with the walkie-talkie walked away, “Stay there, I’m coming down.”, said Miyata and could be heard running. Jay and Woods gave each other a confused look. As Miyata was making her way down from the rooftop, Miya turned around and saw Jay and Woods still had their hands up.

“You can put them down now. We’re safe.”, said Miya and turned back around. Jay and Woods lowered their hands with hesitation. Jay slowly picked his gun up again. Miyata came running out of the main door of the building on the left meanwhile three other people rushed out from a building further down the street. Miyata ran up to the fence.

“Oh my God, it’s really you.”, both of the sisters began to cry while they went up close to the fence, “We all thought you were dead.”, said Miyata as tears ran down her face.

“We?”, Miya's heart sank, “Is Kano and dad here?”, asked Miya while she grabbed Miyata’s hands through the fence.

“We’re all here.”, said Miyata with a relieved smile. Miya smiled back. Miyata then noticed Jay and Woods standing behind Miya.

“Who are they?”, asked Miyata which prompted Woods to smile and wave awkwardly but as he did it, he became aware of his awkward mannerisms and stopped immediately. As he stopped, he looked at Jay who looked at him with judgment. Woods quickly turned his gaze back to the fence again.

“They helped me get here.”, Miya pointed back at them, “The tall guy, Woods, he heard your radio broadcast about setting up a safe zone here in Charleston. As soon as he said that the broadcast came from the military, I knew it had to be you.”, said Miya. Miyata exhaled and shook her head.

“Dad was right. That was his idea. He did it in hopes of you hearing it and getting here.”, said Miyata and let go of Miya’s hands as the people from the rooftops came out of the buildings.

“Let’s get you guys inside.”, said Miyata. Miyata and the other people all went around the fences and detached the fence from the cement blocks so they could lift it up. While they were lifting it, Ozawa, Corporal Hersh and Officer Jones came into sight behind the crowd of people.

“Dad!”, yelled Miya with a huge smile as she made eye contact with her father. He smiled back for a brief moment but then changed his expression from overjoyed to worried as he looked at something beside her. She looked to her side to see what he had noticed and then saw Jay standing beside her. Chuckling with a slight smile on his face. She then turned her gaze back to her father and looked at him with confusion. Jay’s and Ozawa’s eyes were locked tight. Officer Jones who was standing beside Ozawa then noticed the same thing as Miya.

“What’s going on, sir?”, whispered Jones to Ozawa. Ozawa slowly put his hand on the handgun in the holster around his waist which Jay noticed and copied his movements.

“Ready your weapon.”, whispered Ozawa and Jones carefully but quickly grabbed the rifle from around his back, which Jay noticed as well. As soon as Miya noticed Officer Jones grabbing his rifle, she turned to Jay who had his hand on his holstered handgun. As Jay and Ozawa held an intense eye contact, Jay’s heart was beating fast. Adrenaline pumping through his veins. He was thrilled but furious at the same time. They had kept an intense eye contact for a while but then Ozawa broke it and looked briefly at Miya and back to Jay. First, Jay was confused but then he realized what Ozawa was thinking. He thought Jay was going to take Miya hostage. But he hadn’t even thought about that. Until now. Because of his revelation, he had to take her hostage. If Ozawa thought that was what he was going to do, then he knew that he was also planning to shoot Jay before he could do so, and the only way to prevent that was by taking her hostage immediately. The clock was ticking.

“What the hell’s going on, Jay?”, asked Miya which made Jay break his eye contact with Ozawa to look at Miya. As he looked at her, he could see Ozawa slowly lifting his handgun in the corner of his eyes. His eyes darted back and forth between Miya and Ozawa meanwhile his heart beat even faster. Miya’s expression grew more and more confused and slightly worried as Jay began to look manic in the midst of his panic. Jay didn’t want to do it, but he knew there was no other option.

“Come on in.”, said Miyata as she and the other’s placed the fence up against a wall. Woods started walking over the cement blocks. Then Jay’s panic reached a crescendo and he looked at Miya with a regretful expression.

“I’m sorry.”, said Jay and immediately wrapped his arm around her throat, putting the gun to her head and pulling her as close to him as possible. He used all his strength to keep her from moving.

“What the fuck, Jay!?”, said Miya with anger and confusion.

After noticing Jay taking Miya hostage, everyone immediately pulled out their weapons and pointed at Jay. Coincidentally Woods stood in front of Jay and immediately put his hands up out of fear and confusion.

“Woah-woah, hey-hey! I-I-I thought- I-I thought I could go in. I-I’m sorry! I-I-I mis- I misunderstood, I’m sorry!”, said Woods while backing up. He then turned around and saw Jay. His expression immediately turned to confusion.

“What are you doing, Jay?”, asked Woods with his eyebrows scrunched. Jay ignored him and kept looking at Ozawa.

“Is he alive?”, yelled Jay to Ozawa. A couple of the people looked at Ozawa with confusion. Ozawa was breathing heavily. His face was expressionless.

“Dad, who is this? What’s he talking about?”, asked Miyata while looking at Ozawa with a questioning expression.

“You know, I didn’t think you would recognize me after all these years, Ozawa. But then behind those cold heartless eyes, I could see fear. And I knew you remembered *exactly* who I am.”, said Jay and looked around at everyone, searching for someone in the crowd of people.

“He’s not here, Jason.”, said Ozawa which caused Jay to lock eyes with him again.

“Jason? Dad, what the fuck is going on!? For once explain what’s happening!”, yelled Miya and grew angry at Ozawa.

“How about I explain? Let me tell you who your father really is.”, said Jay, which made Ozawa respond immediately.

“I did it to protect my family, Jaso-”, said Ozawa before being interrupted by Jay.

“I don’t give a fuck, Ozawa! You took justice from me! You took the only thing I had left in my fucking life!”, yelled Jay with a choked speech. Woods looked at Jay with sorrow as a tear fell down his cheek.

“Your son ripped my life in half and then *you* came and took the other half. Where is he, Ozawa?”, asked Jay while shaking with rage and sadness bundled in one.

“What is he talking about, dad?”, asked Miyata and looked at Ozawa with a confused anger. “Is he talking about Kano? What’s going on?”

Ozawa turned to Miyata and then back to Jay while remaining silent. Jay could see the gears in Ozawas head turning, trying to think of what to say.

“Let me rip the band aid off, your brother killed my parents and then your dad threatened me to stop me from suing.”, said Jay and